One selling point for using an HTTP API is that it can serve as a generalized backend for all your client applications. You could start by building a client-side application that uses an HTTP API. Later, you could add a mobile app that uses the same HTTP API, making little or no modification to your ASP.NET Core code.

If you're new to web development, HTTP APIs can also be easier to understand initially, as they typically return only JSON. Part 1 of this book focuses on minimal APIs so that you can focus on the mechanics of ASP.NET Core without needing to write HTML or CSS.

In part 3, you'll learn how to use Razor Pages to create server-rendered applications instead of minimal APIs. Server-rendered applications can be highly productive. They're generally recommended when you have no need to call your application from outside a web browser or when you don't want or need to make the effort of configuring a client-side application.

NOTE Although there's been an industry shift toward client-side frameworks, server-side rendering using Razor is still relevant. Which approach you choose depends largely on your preference for building HTML applications in the traditional manner versus using JavaScript (or Blazor!) on the client.

Having said that, whether to use HTTP APIs in your application isn't something you necessarily have to worry about ahead of time. You can always add them to an ASP.NET Core app later in development, as the need arises.

SPAs with ASP.NET Core